

How Teacher–Student Relationships Support Motivation and Identity in English Language Learners

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I have never really seen myself as just a content teacher. I see myself more as a relationship builder, someone who creates the kind of space where students feel safe to grow. I picture the classroom like a garden. Students are the seeds, and teachers tend the conditions: trust, safety, and care. When those elements are in place, growth happens. Sometimes it is slow. Sometimes it catches you by surprise. But it is always rooted in connection.

Some of the most meaningful lessons I have learned as a teacher have not come from books or training. They have come from watching what actually matters to students, what they care about, how they see themselves, and what they dream their futures to be.

I have been teaching English for over 15 years now, in Milwaukee, in Kyoto, and across contexts. One thing I have seen again and again is that students may forget the content, but they remember how they felt in your class. The relationships we build often outlast the grammar points and test scores.

This image of the garden connects to how Hubbard and Power (1999) describe teacher inquiry. They explain it as more like tending a backyard garden than managing a large-scale farm (as cited in Dana and Yendol-Hoppey, 2020, p. 5). Their words stuck with me because they reflect the kind of work I try to do: noticing each student, responding to local conditions, and creating something that grows over time.

“When I speak English, I can be a different person.” This is something that a Japanese university student said to me early on in my time teaching in Japan. Her words have literally never left my mind and speak volumes about how language and identity are linked. It is not just about grammar. It is about how students see themselves and who they are becoming, and how we as teachers are connected in that process.

This inquiry asks how building relationships with students can support their imagined identities and help create a classroom culture that encourages motivation and language risk-taking. The study draws from conversations with English teachers in Japan, where cultural norms, shyness, and long-term goals all shape how students participate and who they imagine they can become.

What the Research Says About Connection

Identity, Investment, and the Imagined Self

Language learning is so much more than grammar rules or vocabulary lists. It's about how students see themselves, how they imagine their futures, and how much they feel recognized and supported along the way. Scholars like Norton (1995), Kanno and Norton (2003), and Kim (2008) have famously helped reshape how we think about second language classrooms, being less neutral spaces of content delivery, but more as communities of identity construction, social positioning, and future-oriented imagination. Leichsenring (2018) adds to this by showing how Japanese students' English use was deeply shaped by how they saw themselves in the language. In her study, some students embraced English as part of a global identity, while others hesitated, unsure of where they fit. This tension around belonging felt especially relevant for my own classrooms in Japan, where I've also seen students shift how they participate depending on whether they feel like English is something they can relate to currently or in their future.

Norton's (1997) follow-up study followed five women in Canada as they learned English while navigating their new identities as immigrants. Through interviews, journals, and observations, she showed that language learning is deeply tied to how people see themselves. Her idea of "investment" has always inspired me because it matches what I've seen in real classrooms. Students don't just bring academic effort to the classroom. They more impactfully bring hopes, fears, and questions about belonging. When they feel seen and safe, their investment in the learning process changes for the better.

Yu and Geng (2020) surveyed 336 Chinese university students studying English and found that those who could picture themselves as confident English speakers as their "ideal L2 selves" were more motivated and engaged than those who could not. That tracks with what I've seen too. When students can imagine a future version of themselves using English, they start to act more like that person in the present. Even small reminders from teachers or assignments that connect to real life can help strengthen and spark momentum into that imagined identity.

Encouragement, Motivation, and the Power of Being Seen

Amirullah, Andrew, and Eckersley (2015) studied five Indonesian high school students and how they imagined themselves as bilinguals. What stood out to me was how a simple moment of encouragement from a teacher could shift a student's whole sense of possibility. In one case, a student said a casual comment from their teacher made them believe they could study abroad for the first time. What pops out is that it was not a formal lesson or a big speech. It was just a small signal that someone believed in them. And sometimes that is what matters most, especially in classroom settings where students are not used to hearing that kind of message.

Cheng and Dörnyei (2007) looked at this from the teacher's perspective. They surveyed 387 English teachers in Taiwan and found that the most effective motivational strategies—building rapport, showing enthusiasm, and setting clear goals—were all relational. Their research backed up something many teachers already feel in their gut: connection drives learning.

That was echoed again in Hattie's (2009) massive meta-analysis of educational strategies. He found that positive relationships between teachers and students were among the most powerful predictors of student success, with an effect size of 0.52. These studies make one thing clear in that relationships are foundational, rather than, again, something extra.

Cultivating Conditions for Growth

For the most part, the research mentioned above is either quantitative or set in the context of immigration. This inquiry, instead, adds a qualitative, teacher-centered lens within the unique setting of Japan. It explores how English teachers, working within cultural norms that sometimes discourage emotional expression, can create conditions where students feel more ownership in growing into confident English speakers.

Getting back to the metaphor that inspired this project, there's a documentary called *The Biggest Little Farm*, where a couple leaves the city to start a regenerative farm, only to discover that nurturing life is far more unpredictable and relational than they expected. That story has stuck with me because it feels a lot like teaching language. Classrooms should not be reduced to numbers. They are living ecosystems. You cannot force growth. You have to tend to it, by paying attention to the light, the soil, the mood, and the season.

Teaching is less about control and more about care. And just like in a garden, growth often happens quietly, after a lot of unseen work. My inquiry builds on the studies above by asking how teachers in Japan cultivate spaces where students feel safe enough to take risks, imagine new identities, and see English not just as a subject, but as a part of who they are becoming.

Listening to Teachers in Japan

This inquiry began with a simple question: *How do teacher–student relationships shape motivation, identity, and risk-taking in English language classrooms?* To explore that, I reached out to six English teachers working across high school and university settings in Japan. Some teach students preparing to study abroad. Others work with learners who see English as just another required subject. But all of them face the same challenge. It can be hard to build meaningful relationships in a context where shyness, rigid schedules, and cultural

expectations make connection feel difficult.

One teacher joined me for a one-on-one Zoom conversation. The rest shared their reflections through a short open-ended survey. These were all teachers I've worked with or known professionally. I trust them to speak honestly about what works, what doesn't, and what stays with them.

I asked how they build connection, how identity comes up in class, and what helps students feel safe enough to take risks (see Appendix A). After gathering their responses, I read through everything carefully, writing memos and looking for patterns in tone, language, and examples. I grouped those into five themes, not as hard data but as repeated signals about what truly makes a difference in classrooms. That's what comes next.

Five Ways Relationships Shape Learning

From these conversations, five themes kept rising to the surface, reminders that the way we connect often shapes the way students grow. These themes reflect how teacher-student relationships influence language learners' imagined identities, motivation, and willingness to take risks in class.

1. Personalization and Presence

Some of the most powerful practices teachers shared were small and ordinary: learning students' names, asking what kind of music they liked, or joining them in class activities. These simple, presence-centered moves helped create what one teacher called "a class where students can feel free to make mistakes" and speak more openly.

Others talked about staying after class to talk, asking students to draw their dreams, or showing up early just to say hi. One teacher said they would "remember details like a weekend test and follow up the next week," which sent a clear message to students that they were cared about as people, not just as learners. Another teacher shared how walking around the room and "joining the activity" helped students feel less intimidated and more equal, as members of the same classroom community.

In my own classrooms, I've found that remembering names, interests, asking a follow-up question, or sharing a bit of my own story might seem minor. But these small moments create the kind of environment where students begin to feel seen and understand that we are all part of a shared learning space, growing together.

2. Emotional and Cultural Barriers

At the same time, participants noted that building strong relationships is not always easy. Several teachers described students who were extremely shy, withdrawn, or simply uninterested in English class. One teacher wrote, “Some students are just really quiet, and it’s hard to tell if they’re enjoying the class or just enduring it.” Another shared, “I have many students who don’t seem to enjoy English, but some end up liking me. And that’s a door.” This idea, that the teacher can become a gateway into engagement even when the content doesn’t connect, came up more than once.

Some students were only attending for required credits and didn’t see English as part of their future goals. One teacher explained, “They often feel English is not for them,” especially if they don’t plan to study abroad. Others mentioned that cultural norms in Japan often discourage open expression. “Japanese students don’t always feel comfortable sharing their thoughts openly,” one noted. Another put it simply. “The students are very shy.” These cultural patterns can make relational teaching more difficult, even when teachers are making an effort to show care.

Time pressure and class size also came up as major barriers. As one teacher said, “I see each class once a week and have over 100 students total, so it’s difficult to connect with every student.” Still, despite these challenges, many teachers described the creative ways they adapt to connect, even if just in small, meaningful moments.

3. Impact of Being Seen

Some of the most powerful stories came when students’ lives or skills were genuinely recognized by their teacher. One teacher described a quiet student who opened up through a drawing activity. Another shared, “A student who rarely spoke ended up staying after class one day just to talk. That moment changed everything for the rest of the semester.” These moments of connection, even when brief, often shifted the student’s entire sense of presence and importance in the class community.

One participant described a time they defended a student during a tense moment with a classmate. “The class atmosphere changed after that. The student started to contribute more, and other students seemed to relax too.” Teachers pointed out that these small acts of recognition can create ripple effects. They matter not just for individual learners, but for the group as a whole. “When a student feels noticed,” one teacher wrote, “they become more willing to try, even if they were hesitant before.”

Across the board, teachers said that when students felt genuinely seen, something shifted. Students began to show up differently for themselves and for their learning. Confidence grew. Participation increased. And in so many cases,

that transformation started with a single, small moment of care and recognition.

4. Identity and Future Goals

Many teachers noted that students do eventually begin to share their dreams, but only after trust has been established within the class community. These conversations often happened subtly. They usually took place on the side of class or during one-on-one chats. One teacher wrote, “I was surprised how often students opened up about wanting to work in hospitality or even study abroad, but only after they felt I was really listening.” Another recalled, “One student told me she wanted to be a flight attendant, but she had never said it out loud before. That moment helped shape how I encouraged her in class.”

Students shared goals like working at Disney, becoming pilots, or traveling the world. “At first, most of them say they don’t have any goals,” one respondent shared, “but if the class is a place where they feel safe, they begin to dream out loud a little more.” Some teachers designed writing prompts or speaking tasks to create space for these reflections. Others said that casual chats before or after class were more honest and revealing than what came out during structured activities.

One teacher put it simply. “When a student starts imagining their future in English, their motivation changes. They stop just doing the work, and they start picturing themselves in a new role.” Over time, the classroom becomes more than a place to study. It becomes a mirror where students begin to see new possibilities for their future.

5. Creating a Safe Environment for Risk-Taking

Teachers emphasized that motivation and identity are closely tied to students feeling safe enough to be themselves. Students need to feel secure before they will push the edge of their comfort zone in English. One teacher said, “When I speak Japanese and make mistakes, students realize I’m learning too. It helps lower the pressure, and they start to relax.” Modeling vulnerability helped normalize mistakes. It also created a more playful, less perfection-driven atmosphere.

Several teachers noted that intentionally framing errors as part of the process made a big difference. One wrote, “I always thank students for taking a risk, even if their answer isn’t correct. That way, they know trying is what matters most.” Others described using peer feedback strategies that felt more like encouragement than critique. “We do pair work with sentence starters like ‘I like how you...’ or ‘You tried ____ and that was great.’ It builds confidence and keeps things positive.”

One teacher explained how using humor and self-deprecation helped shy students open up. “If I laugh at myself for messing up a word or mispronouncing something in Japanese, students feel safer doing the same in English.” Across all responses, there was a shared understanding. Risk-taking in a classroom does not just happen. It has to be nurtured, invited, and protected by the teacher.

What Grows When Students Feel Seen

These findings suggest that teacher–student relationships are not just a nice bonus in language learning. They are often the very soil where motivation, identity, and risk-taking begin to take root. Students do not take big academic leaps because of grammar drills or worksheets alone. They do it because they feel safe, seen, and supported. When that happens, they begin to imagine more for themselves.

Many teachers spoke about the power of small, personal gestures. Asking about a hobby, remembering a goal, or following up on a tough day may seem minor on the surface. But these moments shape how students show up for themselves. Students who felt connected to their teacher were more likely to participate, take risks, and share who they were becoming. And in many cases, that shift began with a relationship breakthrough, not an academic one.

These insights align with Norton’s (1997) concept of investment, Hattie’s (2009) recognition of teacher–student relationships as a high-impact factor in learning, and Yu and Geng’s (2020) finding that students who can imagine themselves as confident English speakers show greater motivation and engagement.

Still, there is tension. Teachers understand the value of relationships, but the system often makes it hard to prioritize them. Some students resist connection. Others carry their own walls into the classroom. And many teachers are stretched thin by large class sizes, strict pacing guides, and limited face time. Building trust takes time, but the structure of school does not always make space for it.

What We Can Do Tomorrow

There are still a few limitations in this project that could guide future inquiry. The sample size was small, and all participants were based in Japan, where cultural norms and school structures are unique. A broader study could include voices from other countries. It could explore how relationship-based teaching looks across different contexts.

This study also relied on self-reported data. Future research could include classroom observations, student reflections, or longer-term studies of how teacher relationships shape motivation and identity over time. It may also be helpful to

look at how teachers develop relational teaching capacity, whether through mentoring, professional community, or personal reflection. There is room to explore how factors like gender, language background, or school type influence this kind of work.

But even with its limitations, this inquiry points to something clear and deeply felt. Relationship-building in the classroom should not be seen as extra. It needs to be part of the pacing, the planning, and the culture of school itself. That does not mean adding scripted icebreakers or surface-level check-ins. It means honoring the quiet, human moves that create trust. Asking how someone is really doing. Circling back to something they shared. Paying attention to who they are becoming.

For teachers, this could mean leaving space in lessons for real conversation, celebrating small wins, and modeling vulnerability. For school systems, it could mean giving teachers more flexibility to respond to students, rethinking how we measure success, and designing professional development that centers classroom culture and emotional safety.

This brings me back to the garden metaphor that shaped this project. Teaching is not about mass production. It is about tending. Adjusting the soil. Moving the plant into the sun. Watering more often when needed. That kind of care takes time, but it is also what makes growth possible. Not every student will bloom in the same way or on the same timeline. But when we create the right conditions, they are far more likely to try.

At the end of the day, this research confirmed what many teachers already know. The relationship is not extra. It is what breathes life into the soil. It is what allows learning to happen. And when students feel connected, they begin to grow in ways we may not always measure, but that matter deeply. I hope these stories remind us that every class, no matter the setting, can become a small garden of growth.

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Appendix A: Survey and Interview Questions

1. How do you build meaningful relationships with your students?
2. Have you ever faced challenges in building relationships with certain students?
3. Can you share a moment when something really clicked for a student because of your relationship or something that happened in class?
4. Have your students ever shared their future goals or imagined identities with you?
5. How do your relationships with students shape how they see themselves and their future goals, especially when it comes to using English or becoming more global?
6. What helps students feel safe enough to take risks in your classroom?

Appendix B: Sample Survey and Interview Responses

In order to protect confidentiality, all participating teachers' names and identifying details have been removed. What follows are selected excerpts from both the Google Form surveys and the one-on-one Zoom interview. These responses aren't meant to retell everything that was said, but to give a sense of the tone, variety, and kinds of experiences that shaped the five themes in the findings section. They offer a small window to see into how different teachers talked about relationships, motivation, and student identity in their own words.

Theme 1: Personalization and Presence

- “Just knowing one personal fact about a student... like their favorite artist or what club they're in... helps me find a reason to check in with them or make a small comment before class starts.”
- “I ask follow-up questions when they mention a trip or a test. It shows I remember and care. It makes a difference in how much they want to talk in class.”

Theme 2: Emotional and Cultural Barriers

- “Some students are just closed off. I think it's cultural too... being too expressive is kind of discouraged in Japan.”
- “I only see each class once a week and have over 100 students. That makes it hard to form deep connections.”

Theme 3: Impact of Being Seen

- “A student who barely talked suddenly started engaging more after I praised a drawing she made during a vocabulary activity. I think it was the first time she felt recognized for something in English class.”
- “Once I stood up for a kid who was being teased by classmates... after that, the whole atmosphere of the class changed. He opened up more, and so did the others.”

Theme 4: Identity and Future Goals

- “When I asked students to write about their dream job, one wrote about becoming a Disney cast member and practicing English for it. That changed how I talked to her in class... more supportive, more targeted feedback.”

- “A lot of students say ‘I don’t know’ at first when asked about their goals. But once trust is built, they start saying things like, ‘I want to use English to work abroad.’”

Theme 5: Creating a Safe Environment for Risk-Taking

- “When I make mistakes in Japanese on purpose, it helps students loosen up. They realize trying is okay.”
- “We do positive peer feedback in pairs with sentence frames. It helps them feel safe and encourages them to speak without fear.”